

CABLE WITHOUT THE CABLE

Almost everything you get on your TV is now available online.
Let us be your guiding light on the path to cable freedom.

Mithun Mohandas

Being a *cablewallah* must have been one of the most secure jobs that you could get into in the '90s. Areas were broken down and distributed among multiple cable-wallahs who'd then not infringe on each others turf. Life was somewhat better back in those days, you only had to pay ₹150-200 and you'd get all the channels that your cable operator could get his hands on. Then came the era of DTH providers who we thought as saviours who'd release us from the clutches of the local cable operator but little did we know we were going down the same road all over again. The *cablewallah* started looking like a lot better. But most of us had already shifted to higher resolution TVs and the cable operator's feed proved to be an eyesore.

We were stuck, again; until competition forced the DTH operators to come up with competitive prices and a-la-carte packages. Soon enough the TV evolved even further and we started getting Full HD content and then came recorder boxes. However, the technology used in these devices was substandard; set-top boxes would be rendered useless when a certain OTA update were to be sent and they had to be repaired over and over again.

Enough is enough, we've suffered for way too long to keep up with this tomfoolery. Streaming video over the internet is starting to seem a better now that there are plenty of services both in India and overseas. One of the best advantages of streaming content is that it's beamed in its original form most of the times and has undergone no censorship across geogra-

phies – the choice to decide for ourselves is pleasantly liberating. We take a look at some of these streaming services:

The Bigwigs

The biggest players in the streaming business aren't based in India and which is why we end up subscribing to a VPN service since the content is often region restricted. But that inconvenience aside, the quality of content on these services remain unmatched by anything local.

YouTube

Content from everywhere in every language and of every type is available on this mother of all streaming sites. Almost every event that has taken place in history that was ever caught on tape can be found on YouTube. More and more TV channels

have started putting their content up on YouTube so you won't be missing a lot. YouTube even has paid content these days and they all have a 14-day trial period so you can check them out before you pay.

Type: Free; VPN: Only for geo-restricted content

Netflix

Yes, we know that if you go to their site you'll be met with a banner that says that the service is not available in our country but with good VPN services – with rates as low as \$4.99 per month – we can enjoy Netflix. This is Full HD content we're talking about and it only costs \$8.99 per month. A little steep but definitely worth it given that it is all VOD and VOD is generally much more expensive in India.

Type: Subscription; VPN: Needed

